I didn't love fancy-dress parties. And I couldn't stand themes. For Willy's last birthday, or the one before, he'd had a fancy-dress party with a theme: *Out of Africa*. I found it irritating and baffling. Every time I'd gone to Africa I'd worn shorts and a T-shirt, maybe a *kikoi*. *Would that do, Willy?* But this was magnitudes worse.

Not one item of native or colonial garb hung in my wardrobe. I was crashing with Pa and Camilla, some days at St. James's, some days at Highgrove, largely living out of a suitcase, so I didn't give a damn about clothes. I looked most days as if I'd got dressed in a very dark and disordered room. A fancy-dress party, therefore, *with a theme*, was my nightmare.

Pass. Hard pass.

Willy, however, insisted. *We'll find you something to wear, Harold.*

His new girlfriend promised to help.

I liked his new girlfriend. She was carefree, sweet, kind. She'd done a gap year in Florence, knew about photography, art. And clothes. She loved clothes.

Her name was Kate. I forget what native or colonial thing she was wearing to the party, but with her help Willy had chosen for himself some kind of…feline outfit. Skintight leotard with (am I remembering this correctly?) a springy, bouncy tail. He tried it on for us and he looked like a cross between Tigger and Baryshnikov. Kate and I had a great time pointing our fingers at him and rolling around on the floor. It was ridiculous, especially in a three-way mirror. But ridiculous, they both said, was the point of the upcoming party.

I liked seeing Kate laugh. Better yet, I liked making her laugh. And I was quite good at it. My transparently silly side connected with her heavily disguised silly side. Whenever I worried that Kate was going to be the one to take Willy from me, I consoled myself with thoughts of all our future laughing fits together, and I told myself how great everything would be when I had a serious girlfriend who could laugh along with us. Maybe it would be Chelsy.

Maybe, I thought, I can make Kate laugh with my costume.

But what would it be? What's Harold going to be? This became our constant topic.

On the day of the party it was decided that I'd go to a nearby village, Nailsworth, where there was a well-known costume shop. Surely I could find something there.

It's a bit blurry, though some things come back with total certainty. The shop had an unforgettable smell. I remember its musty, moldy funk, with an